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The Mitsue Project

Ecology · Energy · Digital Infrastructure for Rural Japan

A 25-year initiative to revitalise an abandoned school and the forest that surrounds it

What the Project Is

The Mitsue Project transforms the closed Mitsue Elementary School — and the aging cedar forest above it — into a living model of rural self-sufficiency. Three elements work together:

- **Forest restoration** — Replacing aging sugi monoculture with native species, healing land ecologically depleted for decades. Native broadleaf trees feed deer, wild boar, and bear — keeping wildlife in the forest and out of crop areas
- **EV charging & energy resilience** — Privately owned solar at the school, EV charging for residents and visitors, and biomass-electric backup power during grid outages. Battery storage to be evaluated in feasibility study
- **Sustainable AI data center** — A small, efficient digital facility inside the old school, powered entirely by local energy, providing infrastructure and employment where none existed. A working model of progress and sustainability as a single coherent system

These are not three separate ideas. Each one makes the others possible.

The Problems This Project Solves

Challenge	How the Project Responds
Closed school, no new purpose	Repurposed as data center & community anchor
Cedar monoculture — ecologically depleted	Systematic conversion to native mixed forest
EV charging needs reliable local power	Data center provides 24/7 baseload demand that justifies the solar + biomass-electric investment
Rural grid dependency, no local power	Privately owned solar + biomass-electric hybrid with EV charging
Shrinking population, no local jobs	Data center operations, forestry, maintenance roles
Blackouts threaten critical services	On-site generation keeps the school, data center, and key facilities running during outages
Wildlife raiding crop areas	Restored native broadleaf forest provides natural food — acorns, nuts — keeping deer, wild boar, and bear in the forest
Rising electricity demand as cars shift to EV	As gasoline vehicles are replaced by electric, village grid load will grow significantly; local generation absorbs this increase without burdening the national grid
Existing rural blackouts	Aging distribution lines already cause outages in Mitsue; a village-owned power

Challenge	How the Project Responds
	supply provides resilience and keeps critical services running

Who Is Behind It

Rob Oudendijk — Dutch electrical engineer, resident of Mitsue since 2012, core hardware developer for Safecast, the global open citizen science network born after Fukushima.

Advisors: Joi Ito (former MIT Media Lab Director) · Ray Ozzie (former Microsoft Chief Software Architect) · San Poisson (Project Manager) · [Advisor 4 — TBD]

A dedicated **non-profit** is being established with local residents, village leadership, forestry professionals, and academic partners.

Why It Can Work Here

Mitsue has what most villages lack: a closed school available for reuse, productive cedar forest within reach, a river for water cooling, and a resident with both the technical background and the deep local relationships to bridge these worlds.

The Mitsue Project — What to Expect, and When

Benefits Arrive Well Before Year 25

The 25-year horizon describes full forest restoration — not how long the village waits for results.

Timeline	Milestone
Year 1	Closed school reactivated; international media visibility for Mitsue
Year 2	Landowners begin receiving income from cedar harvest
Year 3–4	EV charging stations operational; biomass-electric unit installed; battery storage if confirmed by feasibility study
Year 4–5	Data center operational; local employment in operations and maintenance
Year 5–10	Data service revenue reinvested into village and forest programmes
Year 25	Native forest established; model documented for replication worldwide

How It Is Financed

The project stacks complementary sources rather than depending on a single funder: **林野庁 grants** (forest restoration) · **METI / NEDO grants** (rural energy resilience and EV infrastructure) · **FIT / FIP** feed-in tariff revenues · **J-Credit** carbon offset income · **data center service revenue** (primary long-term income) · **impact investment and philanthropy** (Phase 0 and early infrastructure).

All environmental, energy, and forestry data will be published openly — so any village facing the same challenges can learn from what is built here. This ethos comes directly from Safecast, which has published over 250 million measurements openly since 2011.

What Makes This Different

Most rural revitalisation projects in Japan either depend permanently on outside subsidy or import a use with no connection to the land. The Mitsue Project is built around the village's own resources — its forest, its school, its people — and is designed to become financially self-sustaining within the first decade.

The data center element is not incidental. It creates the stable, round-the-clock energy demand that makes solar and biomass-electric generation economically viable — and its backup power infrastructure extends naturally to the whole community during blackouts. The three pillars reinforce each other in a way that cannot easily be replicated with only one or two of them. Together they set a working example of how rural communities can integrate technological progress with ecological sustainability — not as opposites, but as a single coherent system.

Current Status

The project is in **Phase 0** — community consultation, feasibility study, and non-profit formation. No major commitments have been made. This is the moment to ask questions, raise concerns, and shape what comes next.

How to Get Involved

There are several ways to support or participate at this early stage:

- **Village residents & landowners** — Join the consultation process; your land, knowledge, and voice shape the design
- **Forestry & energy professionals** — Feasibility input, technical review, and partnership on implementation
- **Investors & philanthropists** — Phase 0 funding for feasibility studies, legal structure, and early outreach

- **Researchers & academics** — Collaborate on open data, carbon measurement, and rural energy modelling
- **Other rural communities** — Follow the project; everything built here will be documented and shared openly

“If it works here, it can work elsewhere.”

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